message to the Sangha. The inscription is greatly damaged; what has survived suggests that, unlike at Sarnath and Kaushambi, there is no reference to officials. Provisions for the Sangha are set forth; Ashoka added a line highlighting the importance of monastic unity: 'The Samgha both of monks and of nuns is made united as long as (my) sons and great-grandsons (shall reign, and) as long as the moon and the sun (shall shine).'[67]

These edicts, focussed as they are on disciplinary punishment for dissenting monks and nuns, make the tradition of Ashoka having convened a Buddhist council at Pataliputra for suppressing heresy seem historical. Whether the council was held before or after these edicts, Ashoka appears as a figure whose power to impose discipline among the Sangha was accepted. It has been suggested that the recurrence of serious schisms made the Buddhist establishment seek the monarch's intervention of the king in imposing stronger measures against factionalism. While segregation—where the offending monk was made to dwell in 'what is not a residence' ('anavasa')—is mentioned in the *Vinaya*, the imposition of white robes on a lay person is not. One historian sees this as a crucial intervention:

> The Sarnath–Kausambi–Sanchi edict leaves no doubt as to the firm determination of Asoka to put down all attempt at creating a schism in the Buddhist Church. The earnest, almost severe tone of the edict and the fact that copies of it are found at all places of important Buddhist monastic establishments presupposes that in his time the Buddhist Church was at least threatened with disruption, to prevent which he was straining every nerve . . . The Edict was no doubt intended to arrest disruption, but that does not preclude us, it may be contended, from supposing that the Samgha had already broken up into a number of sections, and Asoka's endeavour was directed against further division.[68]